

Casey Jones
City Council Representative, District 3
City of Pensacola
222 W. Main St.
Pensacola, FL 32502
cjones@cityofpensacola.com
(850) 903-2058

Sept. 24, 2024

Reconnecting Communities Program
U.S. Department of Transportation
1200 New Jersey Avenue SE
Washington, DC 20590

Re: Letter of Support for The Escambia Bay Waterfront Access Study

Dear Reconnecting Communities Program Team,

As the City Council Representative for District 3 in Pensacola, I am writing to express my strong support for the Bluffline project and its application to the Reconnecting Communities Pilot Program. The Bluffline represents a transformative opportunity for our city, reconnecting communities across Pensacola to key amenities, transportation networks, and recreational spaces through the creation of a continuous 15-mile greenway. Much of the corridor that would be studied under this grant lies within my district, and I view this project as an important step forward in realizing the larger vision of both the Bluffline and the City of Pensacola.

The Bluffline project is fully aligned with several City of Pensacola plans and initiatives, which prioritize improved access, sustainability, and community resilience:

- **The Waterfront Framework Plan:** The Bluffline directly supports the city's vision for developing waterfront access and recreational spaces. By reconnecting neighborhoods to Escambia Bay and integrating pedestrian pathways, this project helps realize the city's goal of increasing public engagement with our waterfront.
- **Climate Vulnerability Assessment:** The recently completed assessment identifies Chimney Park and its surrounding areas as climate vulnerability hotspots, particularly at risk from flooding and storm surges. The Bluffline's incorporation of green infrastructure solutions, such as bioswales, rain gardens, and a living shoreline, addresses these vulnerabilities by improving stormwater management and enhancing environmental resilience, particularly in low-lying, flood-prone areas.
- **The Reimagined Jackson Street Initiative:** This initiative, which envisions revitalizing the Jackson Street corridor, complements the Bluffline's multi-use path connecting Idlewood Avenue and surrounding neighborhoods to Jackson Lakes. By providing safe, accessible routes for pedestrians and cyclists, the Bluffline reinforces the city's broader objectives for enhancing connectivity and promoting active transportation along key corridors.

The Bluffline will play a critical role in advancing the City of Pensacola's goals for equitable development, environmental sustainability, and economic resilience. It will provide safe, non-motorized transit options for all residents, including underserved communities, enhancing access to educational institutions, job centers, and recreational spaces. This project will also

support the city's long-term sustainability goals by reducing vehicle dependence, improving air quality, and promoting public health through expanded access to green spaces.

As the representative for District 3, I am particularly excited about how the Bluffline will reconnect my district with vital resources and contribute to the overall revitalization of Pensacola. The project's alignment with key city plans and its focus on resilience and connectivity make it a powerful tool for fostering long-term growth and quality of life for all residents.

I fully endorse the Bluffline project and urge your favorable consideration of its application for the Reconnecting Communities Pilot grant.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'Casey Jones', with a stylized, cursive script.

Casey Jones

City Council Representative, District 3
City of Pensacola